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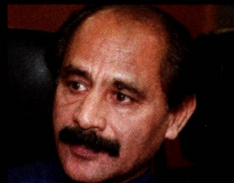
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India's favour. Pakistan has now raised fresh objections on the Kishanganga project in Jammu and Kashmir and the issue is hanging fire.

What needs to be done: Modern hydrological technology is available to settle the claims of both sides and to allay the fears about depleting water levels. Both sides should look for ways to harness power through joint hydropower projects and must accelerate talks to settle the water disputes bilaterally, even if it requires political intervention at the highest level.

7. Expand Economic Cooperation

Good economic links often create interdependence that can help the relationship. Even though India has given most favoured nation (MFN) status for trade to Pakistan, Islamabad has not given MFN status to India, which is retarding the economic relationship. Despite these impediments, bilateral trade has grown from \$400 million in 2004 to \$2.25 billion in 2009 because of some cross-border trade. Despite figuring in the list of CBMs between the two sides, measures to promote bilateral trade such as a liberal visa regime for businessmen and more flights, links con-

tinue to be held hostage to the political relationship. This needs to change.

What needs to be done: Hold a meeting between the two commerce ministers and chalk out an action plan to promote bilateral trade. Granting transit rights to each other will boost economy on both sides and generate employment. These economic links will help build trust between the two sides.

8. Ceasefire on the LoC

Both the countries are nuclear armed and any skirmish or accidental incident can easily escalate into a full blown war. While the ceasefire on the LoC and international border has held for some time, according to Indian intelligence sources, over 110 violations have been reported since 2003. In 2010, six ceasefire violations have been reported on the international border so far, including the killing of a senior officer of the Border Security Force.

What needs to be done: India must reiterate its earlier proposal of a treaty of peace on the LoC. Additionally, the two sides should ink a protocol, holding sector commanders and field officers accountable for any breach in ceasefire or any unprovoked firing.

9. Implement Kashmir Back Channel Proposals

The back channel dialogue has moved from Dubai, Bangkok to London and parleys between the prime minister's Special Envoy S.K. Lambah and Pakistan's National Security Adviser Tariq Aziz brought forth some creative proposals on Kashmir on issues ranging from self rule, autonomy to increasing cross-border cooperation between the two sides of Kashmir while maintaining the status quo on the areas under their control. In fact, India had even sent a non paper to Pakistan just days ahead of the Mumbai attacks and the proposal was frozen following that attack. Many earlier CBMs, like the cross-border trade, are yet to be picked up.

What needs to be done: Pick up the threads and make fresh efforts to seek return of Indians who crossed over to POK. Begin consultation with all stakeholders, including the hardliners in both sides of Kashmir, to discuss proposals of greater autonomy, and demilitarisation and decentralisation of Kashmir on both sides.

10. Promote People-to-People Contact

The peace constituency on both sides needs to be nurtured with fresh initiatives. Pakistan has recently allowed Indian Bollywood movies to be released in cinemas in Pakistan.

What needs to be done: New Delhi should consider allowing Pakistani serials to be telecast on Indian channels. Both countries should consider a visa-free regime for academics, media and business people. Out of 100 CBM proposals exchanged with Pakistan, almost 30 concern expanding people-to-people contact. These proposals need to be implemented, provided cross-border terrorism ends. As a BEST member puts it, "Dialogue with Pakistan should not be abandoned. Such an engagement is necessary to reduce differences. In a relationship of such complexity, dialogue offers the best way forward." ■

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